be individually towed by a Tusker (Border Roads) tractor over a four-kilometre stretch, which at places was all mud and slush.

After spending a bitterly cold night at Senge, the men now had to march across Se-la as very few vehicles could be taken beyond Senge due to the impossible road conditions. The men, not being acclimatized, found the going very difficult. Some even started vomiting blood. To make matters worse, it started to rain heavily as soon as the first company crossed Se-la. Temperatures plummeted further and it became very, very cold. A large number of the men, who were mainly in cotton clothing, started complaining of headache and fever. Rikh decided to stop at Nuranang, which was a small Tusker camp on the northern side of Se-la. At the time, there was no organized accommodation at the camp. Two companies had to squeeze into the Tusker's sheds, which at least provided some protection from the incessant rain and the elements. The third company slept in the open under improvised shelters made by tarpaulins stretched across vehicles.

On 14 September, the three companies left Nuranang for Jang at about 8 a.m. Due to the large number of men who were sick, the march was very slow. Fortunately, it had stopped raining. Four hours later, dropping down the winding road to Jang, the men were relieved to find decent accommodation at the Tusker camp, which was also known as the convoy ground. Despite the terrible conditions during the march across Se-la, the morale of the battalion remained extremely high and, despite the sickness amongst the troops, not one man fell out. In the afternoon the weather cleared up further, allowing the men the luxury of a bath in the Mago Chu (Tawang Chu) that flowed just below the camp. Across the river, halfway up the forward slopes of Bum-la, the sun was catching the yellow roofs of the Tawang Monastery, which was still another seven gruelling hours away. By 16 September, Major Pant along with the rest of the battalion had also reached Tawang.

Meanwhile, Brigadier John Dalvi and his Brigade HQ were getting first-hand experience of the ground conditions in and around Lumpu, which was entirely reliant on air drops for maintenance. 'I watched air drops at Lumpu and found to my chagrin, but not surprise, that 30 to 40 per cent of the parachutes were not opening out and the drops were total losses. The reason for this waste of air effort was due to our policy of retrieving and re-using